

“There’s flexibility and security and we are somewhat in between...”

Eugene Kaspersky is a leading expert in information security and the founder of Kaspersky Lab, a company producing anti-virus and other computer security products. He visited India recently, and Digit's Edward Henning caught up with him at his hotel in Delhi.



EH: You have described the situation with modern aeroplanes where the onboard networks can be attacked. The passengers’ network which can connect to the internet is also physically connected to the pilots’ network. How aware are the aeroplane manufacturers of this threat? And do they care?

K: We got this news about this mistake in the Dreamliner, the Boeing 787, and the first person who came to my office was our lawyer. I said, “Do you know of this news?” and I explained that there was a certain mistake and whatever. And he said “I can’t believe it; this network has to be physically disconnected” — so our lawyer understands security more than these guys.

EH: You have described how operating systems are flexible and functional and therefore as a result are not secure. If you go out in the physical world, because of the threats of terrorism — that’s on everybody’s minds here in India right now — we are now prepared as members of the public to accept greater restrictions on our freedom in order to protect ourselves. Do you think a tipping point will come where we’ll say “OK, stop Microsoft, we want really secure operating systems, we don’t care if there’s less functionality, we need security above and beyond everything else”?

K: Actually there are two sides; there’s flexibility and security and we are somewhat in between and if the situation is getting more aggressive, if there are more attacks, such as terrorist attacks with airports for e.g., with more attacks they are getting less flexible and more secure. Like now to enter this hotel; you’re not flexible at all.

EH: And that’s a good thing

K: And the same is happening with operating systems. If you see that there are more cyber criminals, I think there will be not so much attention from the public. There is a cost to business, but others just don’t recognise it as a serious problem. But if it comes to cyber terrorism, I think we will be forced to use more

secure operating systems. But it doesn’t mean that Microsoft will leave because by (using) default configurations you may make the Microsoft Windows secure, it will just not accept any other application but Microsoft’s.

EH: Well, they have been trying to move in that direction for many years anyway.

K: There are companies that share our business, they configure their desktops, their windows desktops at enterprises in a secure way. But it is not possible to install any application

EH: So, what OS do you personally use?

K: MS Windows XP SP3. I even use Internet Explorer, but I have a special configuration for security, so I am safe.

EH: So many people are just complacent, they think it will happen to somebody else, it won’t happen to them, it’s very difficult to make people sit up and listen and take notice, is it not?

K: Now it’s better because now people, they see, they know that at least some friend or friend of a friend lost some money or was badly affected, so now they pay more attention. The problem is that they do not pay enough attention in the social networks. They think in a community, they trust everyone in a community, they give out some data, some personal information — sometimes it’s enough to develop a very dedicated attack or to have some serious affects on the person.

EH: But the whole idea there is to make your personal information available to as a wide an audience as possible.

K: Again, there has to be some kind of balance. If everyone is friends, you can publish anything you want. If there are criminals around, you don’t publish any data. So you have to find a balance. I am not registered in any social network. Well, actually, I am registered in one, but when I came to publish some personal data, I just stopped and then I never used it. I don’t even have my picture on it. Just the year of birth.

It’s dangerous. It’s very useful for people who live in cities because people just feel alone. So they need to have some community and this is the place for them. But at the same time...

EH: On another subject, correct me if I’m wrong, cloud computing as described by many